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MARCUS LOURDES

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“Black sheep” is such an ugly term. However, it is what I am, as the only Lourdes in the extended family not employed by the firm. That is very much my mother’s work. A professional skater herself during the 1950s, when Talia Astor married and became Talia Lourdes she made me the receptacle for the career dreams she’d set aside to have a family. I took to it well, officially registering with the ASA in 1989.

Still, the rest of the family never understood. I was “the other” at every gathering, in every photo. When business was discussed at the family table, no questions were directed at me. No one even made eye contact with me.

And so I skated. I skated hard until that anger left my body through my limbs, melting the ice and connecting me to the rest of the world.

I won my first real award, the SAIST, just three years after I began skating. My mother and I got to travel to a tiny village outside of Stockholm where we stayed in a small, drafty cabin. It was perhaps the happiest time of my life because it was the first time I found myself entirely surrounded by people who appreciated my talent instead of dismissing it. It was the first time I got to skate outside the shadow of my family under the shining approval of my dear mother.

The continued pursuit of that feeling of respect from my mother, more than anyone else, is what drove me throughout the decade-plus, international career that followed. The pursuit won me another SAIST award in ’99, among countless others.

Who would have ever suspected that years later, shortly after my mother passed away and left me all of her worldly possessions, I would settle down here in Colorado of all places?

Imagine my shock when I arrived in Three Pines for the first time and, with a single whiff of alpine air, was instantly transported back to my days training for the SAIST. I never wanted to become a fixture of the landscape, but simply, I fit in here.

Skating was on everyone’s minds. My own skills and career were respected, and

after my second day, I was offered a position by Carol Donnelly herself as a “resident legend” in the most beautiful natural landscape I’d ever seen.

I soon met her former partner, Nathan LaPalma. Seeing him coaching in his humble town created a complex clash of emotions for me about the man. He was competitive but affable, homespun yet still forever an Olympian, even as his professional career ended and his future sloped down ahead. It takes a certain kind of person to reach the peak of the world and return home to a small town like a salmon, interested in claiming nothing more of the world. I harbored an instant distaste for his lack of ambition and self-respect.

Ambition, however, is a double-edged sword, and my own fingers have always been covered in bleeding nicks. While my time at the Three Pines Ice Rink seems to be spent defending myself from this one-sided competition with Nathan’s ego, it appears that dear old Carol has spent her years developing quite an expansive vision.

We’ve been speaking about the scope of her nonprofit foundation, called Futureskaters or some such, and such was her heartfelt belief that tears were rolling down her cheeks. I applaud that, and her selfless desire to give back to those who haven’t had the opportunities she has.

Of course, with the global apparatus and purse strings of the family firm at my fingertips, I am beginning to see the opportunities that Three Pines is presenting to me: a possible new protégé in one Harrison Campbell, so talented and so thirsty for glory and so evidently explosively frustrated with his coach. I’ve heard their arguments echoing through the rink at all hours of the day, and I can’t help but feel as though it’s only a matter of time before Harrison snaps and quits. When that happens, I’ll be more than happy to coach him in Nathan’s stead. I think he and Lillian, my only current student, will get along like a house on fire.

Beyond that, lately the Lourdes in me can’t help but notice the opportunity for bigger business here. Walking down Carpenter Avenue, taking my espresso by the Overlook, it strikes me how much the rest of the planet would love to spend time and money here in our little slice of American heaven. The money that would bring. While I enjoy aspects of the quiet life, I still retain a taste for the finer things, and neither cars nor caviar typically pay for themselves.

And still, this morning, my mind plays out what The Lourdes Group could mean for the next generation of skaters and for this tiny mountain town. This action would irrevocably change it, of course, but only in death are things ever the same. Of course we’d have to put sanctimonious old Nathan in his place before he smells change in the wind and begins barking orders.